

Exercising Safely with Pre-diabetes, High Blood Pressure or High Cholesterol

Physical activity can support better health for many adults with common risk factors. Start low, go slow, and check with a doctor before starting if you have a condition or are unsure.

General safety first

Begin with comfortable activity, such as easy walking for 10-15 minutes. Add time before adding speed. Warm up for a few minutes, cool down, drink water, and avoid sudden hard efforts if you have been inactive.

Stop activity and get help if you have chest pain, faintness, severe breathlessness, a racing heartbeat that feels unusual, sudden weakness, or pain that does not settle. If symptoms feel urgent, call 995.

Starting point	First step	Build towards
Not active now	10-minute easy walks	More days each week
Some walking	Slightly brisker pace	Longer brisk blocks
Ready for strength	Sit-to-stand, wall push-ups	2+ days weekly

If you have pre-diabetes

Aim for regular movement through the week. A walk after meals can be a gentle way to reduce long sitting and support blood glucose control. Include strength activity because muscle helps the body use energy well. Keep snacks and meals sensible around longer activity, and avoid pushing through dizziness or unusual shakiness.

If you have high blood pressure

Choose steady activities such as brisk walking, cycling, swimming, or low-impact classes. Breathe normally during strength exercises; do not hold your breath while straining. Build effort gradually and avoid sudden all-out bursts unless a doctor has said that level is safe for you.

If you have high cholesterol

Focus on consistency. Brisk walking, active commuting, swimming, dancing, and group classes all count when done at a moderate effort. Add strength work to maintain muscle and support everyday function. Pair exercise with heart-friendly eating habits for the best overall routine.

Make it realistic

Pick a time that fits your week. Morning walks, mall walking during hot weather, community centre classes, and short home routines can all work. If you miss a day, restart at the next planned slot instead of trying to make up everything at once.

Key points

- Check with a doctor before starting if you have a condition or feel unsure.
- Start low and go slow, especially after a long inactive period.
- Stop if warning signs appear, and call 995 for urgent symptoms.
- Include both aerobic movement and strength activity.
- Choose activities you can repeat safely every week.

When to talk to a health professional

Speak to a doctor before increasing intensity if you have chest discomfort, breathlessness at rest, dizziness, recent hospital care, foot problems, eye problems, or any personalised restrictions.

This guide is sample content written for the LiveWell Coach workshop. It is general information, not medical advice. If you have symptoms or a health condition, speak to a doctor.